

A DUAL BURDEN
Roshni Sharma, a patwari tasked with maintaining land records and tax collection, stands outside a Revenue Police chowki in Pauri Garhwal. The 27-year-old revenue official also handles policing duties across all seven villages under her jurisdiction

ARUN KUMAR

The Policing Gap

Still governed by a colonial-era system, **large areas of Uttarakhand rely on untrained revenue officials to police modern crimes**, with rising costs to justice and public safety

By **AVANEESH MISHRA** *in Dehradun and Pauri Garhwal*

A NARROW, SLIPPERY TRAIL CLIMBS STEEPLY FOR 100 METRES BEFORE YOU REACH the remote *chowki* in Jakhnikhal tehsil of Pauri Garhwal district. The outpost is a rundown two-storeyed structure, its central hall serving as a shared office for several patwaris—revenue sub-inspectors tasked with policing dozens of villages between them. A rusted lockup now holds old documents and body bags; a toilet has become a records room. A few cracked chairs flank a bench; faded maps hang loose on the walls. Roshni Sharma, 27, has been posted here just a few months. "We handle land records and police work, both," says the young patwari, who has seven villages under her jurisdiction. "It becomes hard to do either properly."

For nearly two centuries, policing in Uttarakhand's hilly interior is carried out not by trained officers, but by revenue officials like Roshni—patwaris, kanungos, lekhpals—whose primary job was to maintain land records, collect taxes, compile census data and issue certificates. This